

## SECTION | 1

# Basic Concepts

## PARTS

Intimacy from the Inside Out (IFIO) is built on the conceptual foundations of Internal Family Systems (IFS), a therapy developed by Richard C. Schwartz that endorses the normality of psychic multiplicity and engages the plural mind. IFS applies the systems thinking of family therapy to individual, couple, and group therapy. The basic premise of IFS is that we all have what Schwartz calls *parts*, as illustrated in common thoughts like “One part of me wants to go to the party; another part wants to stay home.” Parts manifest in a developmental sequence throughout life, with their own personalities, temperaments, and a full range of feelings. We can notice the feelings, thoughts, and sensations of our parts, and we can talk to our parts. If we ask about their motives, they generally answer. Most vitally, regardless of their behavior, our parts want for us what we want: connection, validation, and love.

Like people, parts live in an inner community, where they develop alliances and get into conflicts. When this community’s most vulnerable members feel scared, unlovable, or ashamed, other parts take on protective roles and try vigorously to do two things: banish the wounded part (the *exile*) from awareness and ensure that the injury never happens again.

We call proactive protectors *managers* and reactive protectors *firefighters*. Managers are the parts who focus on maintaining social connections and aim to conceal qualities they associate with weakness or badness. Their main tool is inhibition, which comes in many forms, including symptoms of mental distress like dissociation or denial; self-directed criticism, warnings, or threats; and bleak views of possibility. Looking for relief from emotional pain, reactive protectors respond to all this inhibition with rebellion and disinhibition. Provided their strategy works quickly, these parts don’t concern themselves with consequences. Popular firefighter options include substance use, eating disorders, pornography, promiscuity, and other high-risk, high-engagement behaviors that offer good distraction. Although some inhibit and some disinhibit, all protectors aim to keep emotional pain out of awareness and don’t understand that banishing vulnerable parts increases their panic and pain.

When exiled parts panic and manage to break into awareness, protectors simply double down on excluding them. This repetitive, draining dynamic consumes a great deal of mental and emotional energy.

Life does not have to be a ping-pong match between inhibition and disinhibition. In addition to parts, we all have an inborn fount of compassion, spacious awareness, and wisdom—a seat of consciousness—of which most clients are not much aware: the Self. To fashion secure, stable attachment inside and out, partners in IFIO couple therapy practice unblending from protective parts and accessing their Self so they can heal wounds, personal and relational. Some experience the embodied Self as an inner spaciousness and calm; many describe it as an unusual alertness, a tingling energy running through their body and the sense of an open heart. The best way to understand this phenomenon is experientially. For illustrations of the Self and opportunities to access your Self with the exercises we provide, read on.

## THE NATURE OF PARTS

### Parts in general:

- Come into existence in a developmental sequence.
- Belong to an internal system of parts and contain a subsystem of parts, which in turn contains a subsystem of parts, ad infinitum.
- Have feelings, thoughts, opinions, and roles within their community.
- Have interests, gifts, talents, and skills.
- Have a positive intention for us.

### Parts who “are”:

- Some parts get rejected for what they are (i.e., for being vulnerable) and live in a state of exile.

### Parts who “do”:

- These parts take on protective roles and exile vulnerable parts in an effort to be safe:
  - o Proactive protectors ward off emotional pain proactively. Their style is inhibitory, managerial, and socially acceptable.

- o Reactive protectors distract from emotional pain reactively. Their style is disinhibited, impulsive, and socially challenging.

## UNBLENDING

The IFS therapist helps parts differentiate (or *unblend*) from the Self. The IFIO couple therapist helps partners differentiate from each other and helps parts differentiate from the Self. The experience of differentiating, or unblending, is like putting on a pair of much-needed distance glasses. When a part separates, we can suddenly see farther and with greater clarity. We can see the perspectives of more than one part and more than one person; we can see patterns and options.

In IFIO, we particularly want couples to appreciate how their pattern of protection (the defensive strategies of protective parts) and their vulnerability always go together. Underneath every protector and every conflict between protectors, we find exiled emotional pain. Protectors are not eager to reveal this pain. In fact, it's their job not to reveal it. But by being curious, we can coax them to become more communicative; by honoring their motives, we can get them to take us seriously; and by being kind, we can summon them closer. Curiosity, validation, kindness, and absolution for any damage they may have caused encourage protective parts to unblend and communicate directly about their concerns and fears so that we can help them.

To find parts, we look first to the body, going inside to notice sensations, feelings, or thoughts. Attention is our calling card. By picking a target and focusing on it, we invite it to pay attention to us, which is the beginning of a relationship. Because managers are inhibitory, they often show up in the joints, diaphragm, throat, jaw, shoulders, and lower back. Firefighters, who activate the endocrine and the nervous systems, can be found in fight-or-flight responses, like an increased heart rate, rapid breathing, and dilated pupils. Meanwhile, exiles are often in or around the heart, gut, or back (Schwartz & Sweezy, 2019). After noticing where and how a part shows up in the body, we ask permission to get to know it. Sometimes other parts object, especially if they are afraid of the target part. For example, some parts are explosively angry with other people or harshly critical internally. Throughout this manual, we will illustrate options for proceeding in cases like this.

But if it's okay to proceed, we start the interview by helping the target part (and all other parts) unblend so the client's Self can embody. If a part is not yet ready to unblend, one option is to go in the other direction and talk with it directly while the client listens. We can also invite a part to embody fully and show us what it feels or wants to do. As we interview protectors at the outset of

therapy, we want them to know that they can get more of what they hope for by doing less. We tell the couple that their protectors are like loyal soldiers tasked with saving vulnerable young children. We want the partners to see their behavior in a historical context and soften toward them. We want their protectors to soften too.

While some individuals are quick to trust the therapist and experiment with unblending, others need a lot of reassurance. The protectors of both partners commonly need to know that (1) asking them to unblend is not an attempt to reject or silence them, (2) the therapist believes both partners have the strength and wisdom to take care of their own exiles, and (3) the therapist will support both partners at all times, even in moments of extreme reactivity. We reassure them on these points by giving them the opportunity to air their concerns. If a part will not unblend, we address its fears thoroughly and proceed only when it's ready. The following three questions, which we illustrate throughout the examples to come, elicit protector concerns about unblending:

1. To the client: "Does any part of you object to us paying attention to the target part?"
2. Directly to a protective part: "Are you willing to soften and separate just a little? You can always go right back to the way things are now if you want to."
3. To the client when protectors have unblended: "How do you feel toward [the target part]?"

## PROJECTION IN RELATIONSHIPS

Protectors have an arsenal of behaviors at their disposal. They use our body, emotions, awareness, and behavior to achieve their goals. One such behavior, which Freud called *projection*, is particularly important in relationships. Projection goes one step beyond denying or distracting from emotional pain by extending an internal process to external relationships. In the process of projection, a protector in Person A criticizes Person B for displaying an attribute that is actually characteristic of another part of Person A—either an exile or another protector—who is being disowned. Protectors can project anything. It might be an intensely negative feeling like fear or anger, a vulnerable state like innocence, an inhibitory behavior like judging, an inhibited behavior like withdrawing or dodging conflict, or a disinhibited behavior like drinking too much or anxiously pursuing a partner. The projection may or may not be accurate for Person B, but it is always accurate for some part of Person A. Like all protective measures, projection is a way of managing vulnerability.

Although projection is central to much interpersonal conflict, couples tend to resist the concept. As a result, it works best to help them reclaim their projections experientially. We have a wide variety of exercises that revolve around a technique Schwartz named the *U-turn* (Schwartz & Sweezy, 2019).

U-turn exercises reverse projection by asking partners to look inside for the driving force behind their conflict. Each exercise guides partners to attend internally, notice what their parts are feeling and saying, and inquire about their motives. U-turn exercises invariably reveal the old injuries (exiles) and long-held beliefs regarding safety that fuel protective reactivity. By doing a U-turn, each partner has the opportunity to witness the other tracing their feelings and behavior from protective reactivity back to exiled vulnerability. Moments of connection around painful early experiences open the door for a relational *re-turn* that is replete with compassion, empathy, and understanding.

## AFFECT REGULATION AND THE U-TURN

The term *affect regulation* describes an individual's ability to modulate strong emotional states and stay present. This skill is critical for couples. Having the faculty to pause, make a U-turn, and unblend from intense reactivity lays the groundwork for self-soothing and returning to calm connection during or following a difficult interpersonal interaction. Because the U-turn is so important for couples, IFIO clinicians have developed a variety of U-turn questions, which are included in exercises and illustrated in many case examples.

### THE U-TURN

- Notice reactivity, thoughts, feelings, and sensations.
- Inquire about what the reactive part *does* and *says* inside.
- Invite the reactive partner to:
  - o Go inside and be curious.
  - o Ask the part to unblend.
  - o Ask who it is and who it protects.
  - o Listen and validate.
- Invite the partner who said or did something triggering to do a U-turn too. The U-turn will reveal what was going on for them internally prior to making the triggering statement or doing the behavior.

## IN-SIGHT AND DIRECT ACCESS

In IFS, we want parts to unblend so the Self can show up. With at least some measure of unblending, the client can be in communication with their parts from their Self. We say be “in communication” rather than “talk to” because only some people have verbal communication with their parts. Others see their parts or feel them kinesthetically, and some people experience parts in a combination of ways. The form of communication makes no difference because all options are possible internally. Any open channel between the Self and a part will serve. When the client communes with a part, we call it *in-sight*. However, when the client’s parts won’t unblend and no inner channel of communication is open, we need another option. Our second option, called *direct access*, involves the therapist talking directly with the client’s parts. Direct access gets a lot of use in couple therapy, especially in the beginning.

In contrast to *in-sight*, direct access must be verbal. The therapist’s Self talks to the client’s part, while the client’s Self (who has not yet been invited to participate) eavesdrops on the conversation. There are two kinds of direct access: explicit and implicit. In explicit direct access, the therapist names the blended part and asks for permission to speak to it directly (“I hear this part has something important to say but is not yet ready to make room for you. How about if I talk to it while you listen?”). Direct access gives the part an opportunity to be forthcoming about its concerns. In our experience, most clients do give permission for direct access, after which we can speak with the part about the client in the third person (“What do you do for Jane? What are you concerned would happen to Jane if you stopped doing that?”).

Implicit direct access is different. Here the therapist simply talks with the blended protector without naming it as a part and without asking it what it does for the client (“I hear you’re feeling really angry right now. Would you be willing to say more about that?”). This looks more like traditional talk therapy but differs in that the therapist knows they are talking to a part. Implicit direct access is a good way to begin if a part rejects parts language or objects to the idea that it is a part. In IFIO, we jump to using implicit direct access often and quickly to validate a protector’s feelings and offer help, particularly when partners are caught in a loop of reaction and counterreaction and the autonomic nervous system (ANS) is activated. We help protectors calm down by validating their feelings, which, in turn, helps the rest of the internal system calm down.

We can’t emphasize enough that getting into power struggles with protectors dependably ensures they won’t give an inch. If you want extreme protectors to unblend, befriend them and stay curious (“Does this part have more to say?” or “Does it need anything from you or me right now?”). In addition, since protectors are motivated by fear, they need to know that the therapist has heard their

fears and has a reasonable way of addressing them (“I hear your concern. It makes sense. Would you like us to slow down and hear more?”). For more on befriending parts, see *Internal Family Systems Skills Training Manual: Trauma-Informed Treatment for Anxiety, Depression, PTSD & Substance Abuse* (Anderson, Sweezy, & Schwartz, 2017).

## UNBURDENING

Once partners are able to reliably unblend from protective parts and the Self is more available, we can begin the process of *witnessing* past traumas and helping exiles to *unburden*, or let go of self-defeating beliefs and unrelentingly extreme feelings (e.g., “Something is wrong with me,” “I’m weak,” “I’m too scared,” “I’m worthless,” “I’m unlovable,” “I’m bad”), which were generated when the internal system believed that shameful personal qualities were the cause of someone else being critical. Exiled parts often carry a variety of burdens, which they will only release if they—and their protectors—feel safe and well connected with the Self. Once these conditions are met and exiles let go of their burdens, protectors can let go of their jobs and do something else.

In IFIO couple therapy, we foster a specific kind of unburdening: *relational unburdening*. As both partners unblend from their protectors and hold each other emotionally, they can take turns revisiting traumatic childhood events. Deep dives into relational trauma from childhood in which both partners’ exiles share an emotionally corrective experience give couples a profound sense of connection and renewal.

## TRANSFERENCE AND COUNTERTRANSFERENCE

Transference and countertransference can emerge at any time in therapy. From a parts perspective, these phenomena occur when parts—either the therapist’s or the client’s—respond to present-moment experiences as if the present were the past. They do this because the exile they protect is stuck in a kind of Groundhog Day existence in the past. By helping the exile who is stuck in this way, the client’s Self corrects the distorted views of protectors (Schwartz & Sweezy, 2019). In our view, clients and therapists are in a parallel process, so countertransference calls for exactly the same attention to protectors and exiles as transference.

### TIPS ON COUNTERTRANSFERENCE

Know your history and check yourself routinely:

- Am I siding with one partner?
- Do I feel friendly toward both?
- Does one partner scare or intimidate me? If yes, what do I do or say in response?
- Do I stay relaxed and regulated when a session becomes intense or their parts react to me?
- Which of their protectors is more challenging?
- Does my system up-regulate or down-regulate in response?
- What is my knee-jerk reaction? What is my first impulse?
- What do my protectors say about the couple? What do my exiles say?
- What was my role in my family (e.g., I tried to protect my siblings from my angry father)?  
Are there times I default to this role with my clients? If so, what is this part trying to do for me in those moments?

## RELATIONAL NEUROBIOLOGY

Research in the field of neurobiology tells us that the ANS can reshape itself (Porges, 2007), which means couples who are entrenched in repetitive patterns of fighting and disconnection because of early relational trauma can change. In IFIO, we explain to couples—using simple, comprehensible terms—that neurobiology underlies behaviors that feel compulsive to them, and their neurobiology is plastic and will change as they practice new behaviors.

In the neurobiology section, we review relevant concepts and offer ideas for employing them in the context of IFIO. In our view, these concepts help couples heal and grow in several ways, including by:

1. Decreasing self-condemnation and partner-blaming while increasing partners' knowledge about how the brain and the ANS affect their ability to stay safely connected.
2. Helping partners stay present with themselves and each other as they learn to modulate the ANS and soothe distress in the body and mind.
3. Illustrating how the team approach to regulating the ANS—which we call co-regulation—is a powerful path to feeling safe and connected at any stage of life.

## SUMMARY



In IFIO couple therapy, we aim for partners to experience a slew of benefits that come with thinking in terms of parts. First, the therapy can bypass the repetitive prologue of parts who spend time in therapy explaining, justifying, rationalizing, criticizing, or disowning problematic protective behaviors. Second, by thinking in parts and seeing their faults and imperfections as just one small part of a robust, vital, and larger whole, clients can challenge paralyzing global judgments like “I’m worthless.” Third, when a client is able to feel curious about a firefighter’s motives, they discover the real problem—the underlying one of vulnerability and emotional pain—and have the (often new) experience of feeling grateful to their firefighter. Fourth, by validating that they needed protection in the past and by being kind to the firefighter parts who provided that protection, partners gradually earn the kind of influence with their firefighters that manager parts can only dream of. Finally, as protectors unblend, partners gain the courage to open their hearts in their relationship.

## GLOSSARY OF TERMS AND CONCEPTS

Like all psychotherapies, IFS and IFIO assign unique meanings to certain words and phrases. Here is a glossary of the language we use in this manual:

- **The 8 C’s:** The qualities that characterize the Self: curiosity, calm, confidence, courage, connectedness, creativity, clarity, and compassion.
- **Blended:** A part is merged with another part or with the seat of consciousness, the Self. Blending occurs on a continuum such that the individual may be empathic and *feel with* a part, be substantially in agreement with a part, or go to the extreme of seeing the world entirely through the eyes of that part (“This *is* me!”).
- **Burdened:** A part carries a burden. Painful beliefs to which parts adhere, extreme feelings state in which parts feel stuck, and recurrent distressing physical sensations that occur without narrative context, which turn out to symbolize or reenact aspects of past trauma.
- **Burdens:** Persistent negative, self-referential beliefs (e.g., “I’m unlovable,” “I’m worthless”); recurring intense, trauma-related feeling states (e.g., terror, shamefulness, rage); and repetitious physical sensations that are frightening or painful.
- **Direct Access:** One of two principal methods used in IFS to communicate with parts. When a protector will not separate, or *unblend*, the therapist can speak directly to the client’s parts, hence the term *direct access*. In direct access, the therapist may either speak to a part explicitly (e.g., “Can I talk to this part directly? Why do you want Pete to drink?”), or the therapist may use direct access implicitly, without stating that they are talking to a part.

Direct access is the usual method to use with children (Krause, 2013) and is often used in IFIO couple therapy.

- **Do-Over:** An exiled part is stuck in the past and takes the client's Self back to that time and place where it instructs the Self to do whatever the part needed someone to do for it at the time. When that is complete, the Self brings the part out of the past and into the present.
- **In-Sight:** A form of internal communication between parts and the Self, which is the approach adults often use to communicate with and understand their parts. Internal communication requires the client to be aware of their parts—visually, kinesthetically, or aurally—and to have enough Self-energy to communicate with them directly. When protectors block internal communication, we use direct access instead.
- **Parts:** Internal entities, or subpersonalities, who function independently and have a full range of feelings, thoughts, beliefs and sensations. These entities, who also display Self-energy when they feel understood and appreciated, vary in appearance, age, gender, talent, and interests. They exist within the internal system where they take on various roles. When they are not exiled by other parts for their vulnerability and are not in conflict with each other over how to manage exiled parts, they contribute in a variety of ways to our wellbeing. IFS classifies parts in three broad categories according to their role in the internal system. Injured parts (or exiles) who feel shameful exert a primary influence on other parts. Orbiting around *exiles* are two different categories of protective parts. Some protectors are proactive, aiming to ward off exiled vulnerability and further injury. We call them *managers*. Other protectors are reactive. They take on the job of distracting from and suppressing emotional pain when it breaks through despite the best efforts of our managers. We call them *firefighters*.

1. **Exiles:** Revealed in feelings, beliefs, sensations, and actions, these parts have been shamed, dismissed, abused, or neglected in childhood and are subsequently banished by protectors, both for their safety and to keep them from overwhelming the internal system with emotional pain. A great deal of internal energy is expended by protectors keeping exiles out of awareness.
2. **Proactive protectors (managers):** Managers focus on learning, functioning, and being prepared and stable. They are vigilant in trying to prevent exiles from flooding the

internal system with emotional pain. In the service of keeping us task-oriented and impervious to pain, they have some standard tactics, including pragmatism, thinking, criticizing, and shaming.

3. **Reactive protectors (firefighters):** Firefighters also aim to ward off emotional pain. However, they are the emergency response team, deployed *after* the memories and emotions of exiles break through to awareness despite the repressive, inhibitory efforts of managers. Reactive protectors use extreme measures that managers abhor, like alcohol and drug abuse, binge eating, excessive shopping, promiscuity, cutting, suicide, and even homicide. They are fiercely loyal to the mission of distracting from emotional pain and do not respond well when others try to control them.
- **Polarization:** Protectors routinely get into disagreements over how to manage emotional pain and end up in adversarial relationships. Over time, their conflicts become increasingly extreme and costly. However, when we acknowledge the good intentions and contributions of each part, they generally become willing to try something new. Once they witness the exile being healed by its relationship with the Self, they are able to let go of their protective jobs and choose a preferred role.
  - **Self:** The seat of consciousness, an innate presence in each of us that brings balance and harmony to inner and outer systems by way of its nonjudgmental, transformative qualities, including curiosity, caring, creativity, courage, calmness, connectedness, clarity, compassion, presence, patience, persistence, perspective, and playfulness. While parts can blend with (i.e., overwhelm and obscure) the Self, the Self cannot be harmed and is available as soon as parts separate, or unblend.
  - **Self-Energy:** The qualities of patience, curiosity, persistence, playfulness, loving-kindness, and compassion that the Self brings to its relationship with parts.
  - **Self-Led:** This occurs when an individual has the capacity to hear, understand, and be present with parts internally and with other people externally, offering the clarity of a systemic perspective, a willingness to take responsibility, and the spirit of loving-kindness.
  - **The Invitation for an Unburdened Exile:** After unburdening, the part can invite any quality of its own choosing to fill the space formerly occupied by the burden.
  - **The Unburdening Process:** Taken as a whole, the unburdening process includes the Self witnessing the exile, the Self going into the past to help the exile in traumatic situations in whatever way it needs, the Self retrieving the exile from the past, the exile letting go of its

burdens (unburdening), the exile inviting new qualities, and, finally, the Self checking in with protectors to see if they are ready to unburden and change roles.

- **Unblended (differentiated or separated from parts):** In this “being-with” experience, the Self is present and available to accompany parts empathically (feel with them), understand their experiences, and have compassion for (care about) them. When parts remain unblended and separate from the Self, not vying to dominate consciousness, we have access to our Self. The unblended state of being often translates into a sense of internal spaciousness.
- **Unburdening:** The moment when a burdened part lets go of burdens (intense, painful physical sensations; extreme emotions; harsh beliefs). This moment is often ceremonial and involves releasing the burden to one of the elements (light, earth, air, water, or fire) as in shamanic traditions. But an unburdening can also be spontaneous (Geib, 2016).
- **Witnessing:** The process by which a part shows and/or tells the client’s Self about its experiences until it feels understood, accepted, loved, and self-accepting.